VERBAL

Reading Comprehension

Inference, Title & Tone

Assignment 1

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PASSAGE - A

This discussion is not concerned with whether Lata's voice is 'good', 'bad', 'authentically' Indian or otherwise, but rather, with the tendencies that come to gather about her singing style and attribute to it the characteristic of 'good' and 'authentically' Indian- feminine voice. As well, what follows is not an argument about causality. And though the discourse of nationalism looms large in what follows, this should not be taken to mean that projects of modernity can simply be reduced to it. Clearly, nationalist ideology is only one of the grids upon which post-colonial modernity is situated. So, while I primarily concentrate on pleasure as a nationalist project, it clearly does not exhaust inquiry into the topic.

During the last and current century, Indian popular music has, in the main, been connected with films and whilst in the early films many of the songs were sung by the actors themselves, during the 1940s this practice gave way to 'playback' singing, where the actors' singing voice was provided by someone else. So, as is well known, in India, singers are not necessarily stars in themselves and, till quite recently, commercial music was sold in the market under the banner of the film with which the songs were associated. Singers cultivated little public presence and rather than the personality of the singer, it was their voice that functioned as a sign. This situation has only recently begun to change and even then can't be compared to the situation of western pop music.

1. The major differences between modern Indian music and western pop music are

I. Modern Indian music is mainly connected with films.
II. Western pop artists cultivate individual public presence and personality.
III. Indian music is based on nationalist ideology.
IV. Indian singers are never stars.

1. I, III and IV 2. II and III 3. I and II 4. I, II and III 5. I and IV

2. It can be inferred from the passage that

1. Actors in early films were good singers.
2. The role of music in Indian films has lost its importance since singers are not stars.
3. Lata is the only authentic Indian-feminine voice.
4. Nationalist ideology is important in studying pleasure as a nationalist project.
5. Before 1940s, actors used to sing for themselves in movies.

PASSAGE - B

"For me", Mahatma Gandhi once wrote, "nothing in the political world is more important than the spinning wheel". The spinning wheel (charkha), for Mahatma Gandhi was not just a tool of political emancipation but it was a metaphor of 'ancient work ethics' and a symbol of economic and social reaction to the British rule. This 'ancient work ethics' and the goal of 'swaraj' (self-rule) in Gandhian framework had to be mediated in and through 'daily life'. For him, 'it is in daily life where dharma and practicality come together' and spinning wheel was a realization of this possibility. Thus any study of Gandhism needs to bring into focus this metaphor of 'ancient work ethics', this site of 'daily life' and this symbol of social and economic reaction.

In Gandhian discourse, the spinning wheel signifies 'decentralisation versus centralized production', 'the sole remedy' for the dwindling handloom industry in particular and India's traditional sector in general, a weapon for stopping the import of foreign goods, the only solution for hidden-mass unemployment of rural population and last but not the least 'a dear forgotten friend of the Indian widow'. The significance of the spinning wheel can be seen in Mahatma Gandhi's insistence that "India as a nation can live and die only for the spinning wheel".

3. The *charkha* is all of the following, EXCEPT

1. The confluence of dharma and reality in daily life
2. A symbol of decentralization against centralized production.
3. The solution for hidden mass unemployment in villages.
4. A symbol of economic and social reaction to British rule.
5. A symbol of the conflict of colonial and indigenous modes of production.

4. The passage explains

1. The symbolic relevance of the spinning wheel to Gandhian philosophy
2. The need of ancient work ethics in daily life.
3. The economic rationale for the propagation of the spinning wheel and Khadi.
4. The need to stop import of foreign goods to protect the dwindling handloom industry.
5. The astute strategies of Gandhi.

PASSAGE - C

Racism serves various ends of exploiters and oppressors and helps them rationalize their past and present actions. For example, Hitler and his followers abrogated to themselves the right to eliminate sub-human races like the Jews. They indulged in genocide and holocaust in order to rid the country, nay, the world, of Jews. In recent times one has seen similar things in Africa. Hutu and Tutsi tribes tried to eliminate each other. In West Asia, Arabs and Kurds have been fighting to exterminate one another because of their mutual distrust based on racial grounds.

Racism is a ploy to allocate social status and opportunity and to grant social status and economic opportunity to certain individuals or groups on the basis of their genetic or ethnic background. This way racism is the very antithesis of the equality of all human beings.

In practice, there are two major forms of exclusion from which discriminated people suffer. The first is generally known as "living mode exclusion". The discriminated people are kept segregated and not allowed to mingle with the dominant race or group socially and culturally. They are regarded as second class citizens and their children are not permitted to attend the same schools and colleges which the children of the dominant group attend. The second is 'participation exclusion' under which the people of the so-called races are not allowed to take part in social, political and economic activities on equal footing with members of the dominant group or race. The former are discriminated in the matter of opportunities for social, political, economic and cultural advance. Both types of exclusion exist on a large scale throughout the world in both developed and developing countries and under democratic as well as authoritarian regimes. According to one estimate, as many as 900 million people suffer from exclusion and discrimination. Thus one out of every seven persons suffers on account of this.

5. Classify the following into living mode exclusion (L) or participation exclusion (P) or neither of these (N).

I. Apartheid in South Africa II. Women in Saudi Arabia.
III. Slavery in 19th century USA.

1. LLN 2. PLL 3. LPL 4. PLN 5. LNP

6. It can be said from the passage that

1. Racism is an inherent function of human behaviour that has been exhibited in various forms throughout history.
2. Racism can be eradicated by ensuring equality of all human beings

3. Racism is a ploy used by exploiting groups to rationalize their behaviour and allocate social status and economic opportunity to their members
4. Racism thrives in modern times due to various political and economic compulsions.
5. Figures indicate that a minority are subject to racism.

PASSAGE - D

A question needs to be asked and answered squarely were these elections fought on the issues of economic reforms. The answer will have to be unequivocally in the negative. In fact, no political party wanted to raise these issues in any meaningful way in the election campaign. The questionable decision of the Indira Gandhi government over three decades ago, of segregating elections to Lok Sabha from those of the state legislatures, was ostensibly to enable elections to Lok Sabha be fought on national issues. This purpose is hardly ever served. The elections to Lok Sabha are as much fought on local issues as are those for the state legislatures and zilla parishads. This is clearly borne out by the electoral promises made by the candidates during the campaign. Therefore, to say that the electoral mandate of recent elections has been against economic reforms is totally incorrect and far-fetched. In fact, if the UPA had fought the elections on the basis of its CMP (adopted after the elections), it is doubtful if it would have got these many seats in the Lok Sabha. It is the left parties that seem to be dictating major policies. One can well ask if these parties with a combined strength of just 62 members in the House of 540 members and that too mostly drawn from three states- West Bengal, Kerala and Tripura, can be said to have a national mandate to change the course of economic reforms in the country. If coalition governments are to be inevitable for decades to come, it is necessary that the rules of the game too are changed. It would be preferable that coalitions and alliances come into being prior to an election and place their CMPs before the voters to enable them to judge the implications of voting them to power. Let us see the likely scenarios in respect of a few of the major issues which would have a significant bearing on the future of the country.

7. The author is of the opinion that

1. The electorate is influenced by immediate local issues rather than by abstract economic issues.
2. The UPA won the elections mainly based on major policies dictated by the left parties.
3. No policy statement or manifesto is necessary for electoral alliances.
4. The Indira Gandhi government introduced instability in the political system.
5. Electoral reforms have reached a dead end.

8. It can be inferred from the passage that the author believes that

1. Single party governments are not likely in India for decades to come
2. Political parties deliberately obfuscate policy issues during elections.
3. A bloc with a regional bias and strength in the house of only 11% should not decide policy issues.
4. The Indian political scenario is likely to see further polarization on economic issues.
5. Contemporary national mandates are, at long last, national in character.

PASSAGE - E

Technology- driven industrialisation has necessarily caused a shift in human values, certainly among those sections of society that have benefited from industrialisation in India. Such people speak and think about liberty and freedom without stopping to think whether there are others who cannot even dream of those desirable conditions of "life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness". The freedom they seek is to "consume" without the responsibility of leaving something for others, or regenerating resources or even a thought for the resources for generations as yet unborn.

The juggernaut of industrialisation leaves most people with the choice of climbing aboard (like the growing "Great Indian Middle Class") over the bodies of the struggling masses, or staying out of the way. Given the enormous momentum of industrialisation, the very existence of those who cannot do either is threatening our farming or tribal communities or Dalits – who have been oppressed for centuries and are even today

oppressed. Reacting to the economic violence of industrialisation, some take up weapons to fight (extreme self-assertion) while some choose suicide (extreme self-abnegation). But for the vast, silent majority this is a "sentence" to suffer the filth and degradation of urban slums, their final earthly destination.

9. All of the following statements are true EXCEPT

1. Technology driven industrialization has created a dichotomy in Indian society
2. The beneficiaries of industrialization are essentially consumerists in nature
3. Farming and tribal communities and Dalits find their existence threatened.
4. The rate of armed conflict (extreme self-assertion) and suicides (extreme self-abnegation) has substantially increased in India
5. Only some people have the option of climbing aboard the juggernaut of industrialization.

10. The passage highlights

1. The dangers of reforms without a human face
2. The declining values of 'consumers' in our society.
3. The failure of the system to prevent suicides.
4. The need to protect the rights of tribals and Dalits.
5. The plight of the marginalized sections of society.

Answ er keys

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1.	3	See the second para ' Indian popular music has...films' and 'singers cultivated compared to western pop music.'
2.	1	See the second para 'many of the songs.... actors themselves.'
3.	5	The other options are explicit in the passage.
4.	1	The passage deals with various symbolic significances of the *charkha* in Gandhian philosophy.
5.	3	See the definitions of 'living mode exclusion' and 'participation exclusion' in the 3rd para and apply understanding of these terms
6.	3	See the second para (as per the fact in the first line of the second paragraph).
7.	1	Read the opening lines 'A question needs to be asked and answered squarely were these elections fought on the issues of economic reforms. The answer will have to be unequivocally in the negative.',of the passage.
8.	1	See 'If coalition governments are to be inevitable...'
9.	4	Read the last sentence. It does not talk of the rate of change in violence or suicides.
10.	1	The first para and the very first line clearly introduce this theme.